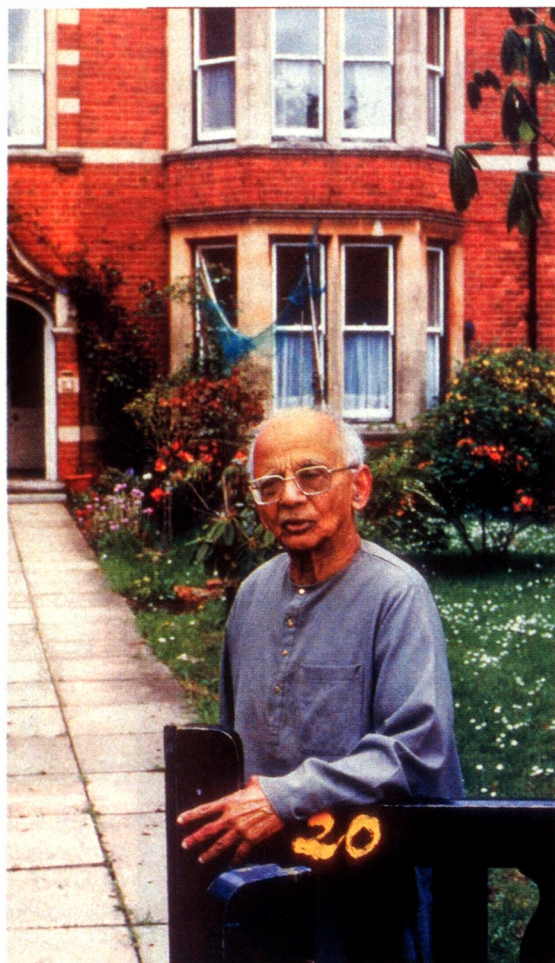




ON NIRAD CHAUDHURI

There are perhaps three references in the *Autobiography* to the writer's small size; and he was, indeed, very small, almost dwarfish, some inches shorter than his father, who (he says) was just under five feet six, the Bengali average. Somerset Maugham, a small man, says somewhere that the world looks different to a small man. The world would have looked very different to Chaudhuri.

Chaudhuri, in spite of all the great names he takes, was not a scholar. He had no idea what scholarship meant. He held on to the idea only because it was the main part of his self-esteem. Take that away and he would have been completely lost. The success of esteem of the *Autobiography* (justified success: it is a great book for four hundred out of its five hundred pages) enabled Chaudhuri to keep on writing. Being Chaudhuri, he thought success had come to him not for his picture of East Bengal and Calcutta between 1890 and 1920, but for his hundred pages of 'scholarship', his ideas about the history of India; and the later books magnified his flaws.

The thesis of his second big book was that Indians were really ancient 'Europeans' (he never fixes these strange people in geography or time) who had been denatured by the pitiless climate...

the culturally denuded mind of the Gandhi who went to England in 1888. He had the most basic idea, a village idea, of Indian religion and the epics, but he didn't know the history of India, not even a school version; he didn't know geography, hardly had a map of the world in his head. He didn't know about books and modern plays, hardly had an idea of news and newspapers. Busy, modern London would have been a horrible shock. He didn't know how to keep his footing; he must have felt he was drowning. The few dancing lessons he took, his violin lessons, and the horrible prospect of his elocution course must have depressed him more than he says. He would have seen how culturally far away he was, and with something like desperation he would then have lost himself in the abstractions of his law studies, cramming, reading right through the English common law and studying Roman law in Latin.

South Africa a few years later showed him that this new world, barely understood, was exceedingly hostile, and even full of physical threat. The shock, the wound, would have been many times greater than the shock of London. He had the law now; it was better than nothing. But he needed more, and so he held on to all the pieces of comfort he could get from European well-wishers and people who came within his orbit, and soon he was a man of many small causes.

These causes, disguising his wound and his primary,

Indian cause, attracted many different people, who saw in him their own personal cause. (Though Tolstoy, Russian nationalist though he was, thought that Gandhi's Indian nationalism 'spoiled everything'.) So Gandhi's many causes made him appear more universal than he was. He came at the right time; the world was oddly vacant; there was room for him; and in 1909 he could get away with the nonsense and anti-modern simplicities of his first book, *Hind Swaraj* ('Indian Home Rule'). The book would not be read in India, not even by scholars (and still hasn't been), but its name would often be taken as a milestone in the independence struggle, and it would be cherished as a holy object. Twenty-five years later, after the Russian revolution, after Hitler, with a world waiting for war, he might have had a harder ride.

And when, forty years or so later, the main cause had been won, and India had become independent, it was those 'outside' causes that made it hard for people to know what Gandhianism was. Was it the dhoti, the spinning wheel, the homespun, the Thoreau, the Ruskin (what was there for Indians in *Walden* or *Fors Clavigera*?), the sexual abstinence, the vegetarianism, the Christian hymns, the refusal to drink cow's milk, the latrine-cleaning? It was impossible for anyone to be a complete Gandhian; no one could make that pioneer journey again; people had to take the one or two things they liked from the menu. In the main they took the homespun; that was the easiest and most stylish item.